

School of Social Service Administration Building

I01



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Address: 969 E. 60th Street, Chicago, IL

Year Construction: 1965

Year Acquired: 1963

Architect: Office of Ludwig Mies van der Rohe,
Gene Summers

Gross Square Feet: 52,599

Primary Uses: Office, library, and classroom

Design Zone: Campus South

Last Major Renovation: 2008, Façade Restoration,
Krueck+Sexton Architects

Comments: The Social Service Administration Building (SSA) is a one-story midcentury modernist design with exposed steel and glass construction located on the main campus of the University of Chicago. SSA was designed by the world famous architect Mies Van der Rohe. This office building has a main floor and a fully occupied basement level. The main floor contains a large reception lobby/meeting area and library. There are also additional conference rooms and classrooms. The lower floor contains a large number of offices and support areas.

The lobby has a 19-foot-high-ceiling and is 120 feet long and 40 feet wide. It serves a dual purpose: as the entranceway to the building and as an auditorium for more than 300 persons.

REGULATORY STATUS

National Register: No

NR Comments: N/A

NR Historic District: N/A

Landmark Status: No Status

Chicago HRS Color Code: None

CHRS Comments: No Comment

1 - Site

Land Ownership Status: Owned

Location - Physical: On the southwest corner of 60th and Elis

Location – Program Adjacency: SSA is near Midway Studio, the Logan Art Center, and Burton-Judson Dormitory

Location Comment: The site is reasonably well landscaped with turf grasses, ornamental shrubbery, accent planting beds, and mature native trees.

2 - Adaptability

Construction Type: Steel skeleton with masonry walls

Accessibility: Entrance – Y; Bathrooms - Y

Floor-to-Floor Height: 19 feet (lobby)

Structural Capability: No Comment

Adaptability: No Comment

3 - Building Envelope

Roof Type: Metal

Exterior Façade: Steel and glass

Exterior Base: Concrete

Exterior Trim: Steel

4 - Heritage and Historic

Heritage - Exterior: Of note at SSA is the use of steel columns built up to form cruciform sections, both for interior supports and as part of the exterior wall. Mies and Gene Summers – the latter chiefly responsible for the SSA design – had been studying cruciform in both steel and concrete for the several clear-span projects they had worked on together in the late 1950s and early 1960s. For SSA, Summers designed a cruciform composed of four wide-flange sections welded to form a box. The cruciform's wide-flange components are of the same section as

the wall's mullions. The webs make up the arms of the cruciform, and the outboard flanges complete a graceful, slender analog to a Gothic pier.

The façade was extensively restored in 2008 by the noted architectural firm of Krueck+Sexton, who have also worked on several other Mies facades including the 860-880 Lake Shore Drive apartment buildings and the iconic Crown Hall on the IIT campus. The restoration included removing and replacing all exterior glass and steel stops in the building, sandblasting and repairing all steel at the curtain wall assembly, and repainting the exterior steel.

Heritage - Interior: Uniquely among Mies's works, the SSA Building incorporates three interior levels within a single-story elevation. Paired entries lead without vestibules to a tall, expansive lounge space, from which elegant twin stairs lead down to an English basement with classrooms and offices, and up to a library and additional administrative space. The interior design, especially of the main hall, employs the Miesian vocabulary of buff brick walls, extensive custom millwork, and exposed interior steel.

The building interior is substantially unchanged since the original construction except for necessary modifications to allow for accessibility throughout. A few pieces of original Mies-designed furniture remain, most notably the low teak tables with travertine tops which were designed and built specifically for this building.

Significant Spaces Identified: N/A

Heritage Culture Elements: No Comment

Architectural Awards Certification: N/A

Heritage and History - General Comments: Prior to the construction of this building the School of Social Service Administration was located in Cobb hall and temporarily in the Home for the Incurables (Young Memorial Building).

5 - Sustainability

Certifications: None

Window Last Replacement: 2008

Weather Stripping: None

R Value Roof/Wall: N/A

Systems: N/A

Deficiencies: N/A